

In Sirukalathur, football is replacing drift with direction

A two-star AIFF-accredited grassroots football club is giving over 150 children **structure, opportunity, and a path** away from addiction and uncertainty.

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Football is often sold as a 90-minute spectacle. In Sirukalathur, it begins at dawn, spills into classrooms and, at times, decides the course of a life.

When FC Barcelona speaks of “*Mes que un club*”, it is not merely branding. It reflects how football can anchor a community. Clubs such as Athletic Club in Bilbao, with its deep-rooted commitment to local identity and player development, echoes a similar idea: football can represent people, place and possibility.

Far from the city, in Kancheepuram district’s Sirukalathur village, that idea has taken root in its own way.

In a village of around 2,000 people, more than 150 children train every week at the Sirukalathur Galatipet Football Club (**facing page**). From a single ground, the two-star All India Football Federation (AIFF)-accredited academy has produced seven players for Chennaiyin FC’s youth teams, one for Bengaluru FC, two for FC Madras, and several others who have gone on to feature in first-division competitions.

Founded by D. Harikrishnan, the club traces its origins to the FIFA World Cup in 2014, when the village began shifting away from bat-and-ball games towards football. Inspired by the tournament’s global pull, Harikrishnan began organising sessions for local children, a small step that would grow into something far larger.

Two years later, in 2016, the club travelled to Kolkata for the Young Heroes football tournament. What followed was transformative.

For a fledgling club in a village that had rarely travelled beyond its district, international exposure was the last thing anyone expected. Spain might as well have been another planet. Yet, two players from that group were selected for a training camp there, and one of them, Rishish, went on to secure an opportunity with Swedish club IK Sirius.